



102 Life In A USB Nutshell



106 The Brightest Bulbs in Town



120 Life @ 24 FPS

Digital Business

How Technology Can Help Your Organisation

Case Study

A Step in Time...

The workings of a little shop demonstrate how tech—at every stage of evolution—can help business productivity

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Munshi Khancha Market in Vadodara (Gujarat), the royal city of the Gaekwads, is far removed from any signs of royalty today. Its bustling alleys are crowded with people and innumerable shops butting out from every wall. From nine in the morning until nine in the evening, the place is a retailer's paradise, at least in terms of the sheer number of customers who pass through. But as crowded is the competition: you cannot sell anything the guy next door doesn't have.

In the midst of such a crowd of opportunities and competition lies the story of a 10-foot-by-6-foot retail outlet, Welcome Store, and its founder Satish Uttamchandani's visionary use of technology. A typical shop that stocks FMCGs, dry fruits and cosmetics, among other items of daily use, this outlet has oodles of technology being used to ease its various operations.

Number Crunching

Back in 1983, Uttamchandani heard about a device called the calculator from friends who had been to Singapore. In the wake of reports that this machine, being startlingly accurate and fast, would reduce the need for mental math-juggling, he purchased a Casio 100. The simple advantage it brought about in speedier customer billing, especially during peak hours, was the fillip for Uttamchandani to explore the role technology could play in his business.

As he studied the brochure that came along with the Casio 100, he saw one with a printer. Three months later, he ordered a piece. This one also gave a printout of the grand total of all the calculations done on it in the course of a day (i.e. daily gross turnover), thus initiating his entry into the world of machine-generated reports.

Coding Products

Early on, Uttamchandani had realised that time saved is money earned. A simple example was the salesman who would have to leave the sales counter at 7:30 pm every day to replenish items on the rack. Were he to remain at the counter it

would mean more sales, especially during peak seasons such as Diwali. After the shutters were down, one day he and his team mulled over possible solutions to save time on the rack filling task every day.

They decided to numerically code 150 of the fastest-moving items among the 1,200. Also, alphabetically-coded



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